Summary of Babur’s Twenty-Five Years

A lot transpired in twenty-five years of Babur’s life. He lost his father at the age of eleven and got the responsibility of ruling Ferghana with a hostile rebellious situation all around. While his uncles tried their best to dethrone him, his maternal grandmother Aisan Duglat Begum could make him stand firm. He always desired to gain Samarkand which he did for a brief period but eventually, it slipped away. It was in the quest to retain Samarkand that he lost his sister to his old Uzbek foe, Shaybāni Khān. When life began to turn even more miserable, Babur had to take refuge in Tashkent, which was ruled by his maternal uncle. But Babur gained no comfort even there. Finally with the short-lived victories and much of miseries for a decade since having become the ruler of Ferghana, Babur reached Kābul in AD 1504 which was once ruled by his paternal uncle Ulugh Beg-II who had died leaving behind only an infant as heir and Mukin Beg had shown the authority to rule. Babur established his supremacy and would stay there until finally making an entry in Hindustan in AD 1526. Babur’s approach and stay in Kābul had been a bloody one. We observe the trait of Timur reflecting deeply in Babur where he keeps slaughtering and making pyramids of skulls.

In AD 1505, when revenues had gone extremely low in the newly established mountain kingdom, Babur decided to enter Hindustan for the first time, but the expedition ended at the crossing of Khyber Pass. The same year he united with Sulṭān Husayn Mirza Bayqarah of Herat, who was a fellow Tīmūrid and distant relative, against their common enemy, the Uzbek Shaybāni. But as Husayn Mirza died in AD 1506, the venture against Shaybāni failed as the former’s son showed no interest in going to war. Yet, Babur chose to stay in Herat after being invited by the two Mirza brothers. He stayed there for around two months and then had to leave because the resources had begun to diminish completely. Later, whatever was leftover, was overrun by the old foe Shaybāni. Eventually, the Mirza brothers fled. Now that Herat was gone, Babur remained the only reigning Tīmūrid ruler. Many princes of the clan came to Babur to gain refuge in Kābul as Shaybāni had been invading the western parts. Eventually, looking at the prevailing situations, Babur assumed the title of ‘Padishah’, among the Tīmūrids. In my opinion, this title was not of much significance as most of the ancestral land was taken and even Kābul had been witnessing Shaybāni Khān’s threat.

Given the circumstances, Babur decided to make a second attempt at one of his most desired lands, Hindustan only to fail again. Humayun was born after the failure of this mission.